

Approaches to Change Management

Digital skills support at Weston College: rationale, embedding, leadership and engagement

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Why change was necessary: external drivers

Regulatory

The Ofsted toolkit embeds digital skills in the graded Achievement descriptors, and inclusion now stands on its own.

Legal

SEND framework, WCAG 2.1 AA and the Equality Act 2010 require assurance over materials and the digital environment.

Economic

Flat funding settlements and a contract not renewed. Compliance could not be bought, so it had to be restructured.

Analysed using PESTLE (Aguilar, 1967)

Why change was necessary: internal drivers

What staff believe

That they are competent in digital practice, including accessibility.

What the evidence shows

Awareness-based indicators score higher than those requiring learned technical action.

Structural fragility

Digital pedagogy expertise concentrated in a single specialist post, now within Quality. A critical single point of failure across 35 areas, nine campuses and 600+ staff.

Cultural gap

Jisc Discovery data from December showed high confidence alongside limited objective competence, so the college drifted out of alignment with its own Quality Handbook.

The knowing-doing gap (Pfeffer and Sutton, 2000)

From project to business as usual

Change dies when it is a one-off event. It survives when it is anchored in culture and process.

1

Taught once, at induction

Assistive technology is introduced alongside everything else, at the most overwhelming point of the year.

2

It never becomes normal practice

Access arrangements must reflect a learner's normal way of working. A laptop cannot be given in an exam to someone who has never used one.

3

The learner loses an entitlement

No embedded practice means no evidence, and no evidence means no adaptation.

Mechanisms that actually embed

Quality Handbook

Writes the expectation into formal standards and brings work scrutiny, learning walks and learner voice to bear. Structural, not optional.

Digital Leads

Socialises change peer-to-peer inside departments. More durable than directive.

Health Check cycle

Institutionalises the change so it survives any individual. Revisited and measured annually.

Why change fails here: change fatigue, and reliance on a single champion. When the Digital Education Manager post went, the framework lost its champion.

Leadership without authority

Mandate

Assumes positional authority and budget control. Orders compliance. Was never available to me.

Influence

Listen to the fear, then answer it structurally. The staff-hold-their-own-data model built the psychological safety that made honest engagement possible.

The objective is not compliance. It is curiosity. (Goleman, 2004)

Diagnosing the real barrier

AC2.3

1

Looked like resistance

Staff were not adopting advanced pedagogical tools.

2

Diagnostics said otherwise

Baseline data showed a foundational digital skills deficit.

3

So the project pivoted

Pause the wider framework, secure the foundations, deliver targeted resources.

If people do not understand the basic controls, no amount of advocacy for advanced tools will succeed.

Why engage stakeholders throughout

Engaging only at launch and closure is management by broadcast, not by influence.

1

Operational reality shifts daily

Stop engaging and you lose sight of the shifts, so timelines and support stop matching what is actually happening.

2

Engagement was the only currency I had

Without positional authority nothing could be mandated. It had to be negotiated.

3

What it bought

Heads of Area gave departmental time. Digital Leads gave a volunteer workforce and a route into every area. Century and Jisc gave diagnostic infrastructure.

Tailoring the message

AC2.4

Vice Principal

Strategic alignment and inspection compliance.

Head of Area

Operational efficiency and minimal disruption.

Teacher

Psychological safety and practical time saving.

Engagement is a source of intelligence, not a courtesy.

Engaging staff during the Jisc Discovery phase identified the foundational gap. It did not communicate the plan. It changed the plan.

Distributed resilience

Sustainable change in this sector means moving beyond models that assume formal authority. Understand the constraints, embed through peer networks, and engage continuously rather than episodically.